Bottleman

By Eric Bogosian

NOTE: This cutting met the requirements for PROSE by the National Speech and Debate Association in 2008. Rules governing the PROSE category have changed over time and this selection no longer meets the requirements for PROSE by the NSDA as it is a monologue from a play.

State rules governing PROSE vary from state to state, so please verify your state's current rules before competing with this selection in the PROSE category.

INTRODUCTION

This past Monday, 36,782 homeless people spent the night in a New York City shelter; the number who slept on the street is impossible to ascertain. Homeless men and women are part of an expanding, often faceless community. When we come in contact with a homeless person, we may feel repulsed, annoyed, even angered as we avert our eyes and think, "Why don't they do something to help themselves?" or "If I look them in the eye, that'll just encourage them to ask me for money" or "They choose to be homeless." Frequently, it is our lack of understanding about the complexities of homelessness that fuels our prejudices and fears about homeless people. Somehow, that gives us "permission" to act less compassionately towards a homeless person — who is, after all, a human being just like us. I'd like to introduce you to Bottleman by Eric Bogosian

(A man talks quickly, nervously, rarely looking at the audience. He constantly hitches his pants and pats his hair. His over cheerful manner covers his fear. He's making conversation with an imaginary listener. He begins by talking to the wall.)

I don't like to complain. I'm not a complaining kind of guy, I'm a happy kind of guy – runs in my family, happiness. Never been sick in my life. Not one day. Unless you count broken bones, which I don't. But I like to stay positive. Stay on the sunny side of the street. You give me a pack of cigarettes, egg salad sandwich, cup of coffee, a newspaper, someplace to sit down, and I'm happy – I'm happy.

I don't even need the cigarettes, I should quit anyway. It's a dirty habit. Unhealthy. Expensive. Of course you can always find cigarettes. People always have cigarettes – they'll give 'em to you. Food's another subject altogether. People aren't exactly walking around with an egg salad sandwich in their pocket – unless they're crazy! And you figure, egg salad sandwich's

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gonna run you maybe seventy-eighty bottles. I'm findin' maybe fifty bottles a day – you're talking a short-fall of about twenty bottles. . . or cans . . . bottles or cans, it doesn't make much difference.

Back in the old days, I used to weigh a lot more than I do now. Used to be on a diet all the time. Always trying to lose weight. I don't have that problem anymore. I'm on the egg salad sandwich diet now. One egg salad sandwich every two days . . . you lose weight like crazy. The fat just flies off . . . and it stays off. I'm gonna patent it. Get a copyright and put an ad in the newspaper. Make a little money.

See, newspapers – newspapers, you can get. You can always find a newspaper, people just leave 'em around. And I read 'em. I wanna know about the world.

It's important to stay informed. I read about a train in Japan goes three hundred miles an hour, gets you there in no time. They got hotels for cockroaches now, hotels for mice. I stay away from hotels. Too much money – who's got that kinda money? Then bucks a

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night, forget it. You figure that's two hundred bottles – bottles or cans – and that's not in my budget.

But it's not a problem. You can always find someplace – there's always someplace to stay. You wedge yourself in someplace. The real problem is the concrete. The stone. They make everything out of rocks and cement! Too hard. Whatever happened to wood? Used to be all the buildings were made out of wood. Used to make benches outa wood. But no more. Because they make wood outa trees, and trees, they don't got them no more.

I saw this tree . . . there was this tree, beautiful tree . . . they dug a hole and put it in the sidewalk. Every day I come to say hello. And this guy was backing up his truck. The truck was making that beep sound – beep-beep-beep-beep—right over the tree, That was it for the tree. That was it. What are you gonna do? It's just in the nature of a tree that if you run 'em over they die. They're not like people – they can't take the abuse.

Take a tree, replace it was a metal pole, then there's no problem. Truck hits the pole, that's it, But

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you lose the leaves. You lose the leaves and the twigs. You lose the wood. Wood is good.

Dogs like wood. I know – I used to have a dog. Walked him every day. I used to say (miming walking the dog): "Come on! Come on! . . . Who takes care of you? Who takes care of you? I take care of you. Who's gonna take care of me in my old age? Who's gonna take care of me?" That's what I used to ask him . . .

He ran away. But that's okay – they gotta eat too, the little ones. Everybody's gotta eat, sooner or later. It's human nature. It's human nature. I like to eat. I like to eat. Kind of a habit of mine, food.
(He holds an imaginary sandwich before his face)

Nice egg salad sandwich. Cup a coffee . . . Cream. Sugar.

I'm cutting down on the coffee. I don't drink much coffee these days. Sixty cents a cup. Where did they come up with that figure, that's the question I want to ask. Should be ten cents! But they got ya, see, they got ya. 'Cause they got the beans. They got the beans. You got no choice. They got a cartel. This OPEC.

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But I don't need coffee. I don't need the coffee. People drink coffee to stay awake – I don't need to stay awake. I'm awake, I'm awake. When I'm asleep I'm awake. You gotta keep your eyes open when you're sleeping, 'cause you find a place to lie down and you don't keep your eyes open and a guy comes back with a baseball bat and that's it – bang, bang, you're dead!

No more coffee, no more cigarettes – that's it!

See, these guys on the street, they like to fight. I don't got that luxury. I'm on my second set of teeth, I'm missing a kneecap, I can't hear in one ear. I'm like the bionic man without the hardware. I'm no Cassius Clay. I'm no Cassius Clay. (Pause) But I stay on the sunny side of the street. I stay on the sunny side of the street. A guy once told me, "Life is like a half a glass of water . . . half a glass of water . . . " (He loses his train of thought; his hand is shaking, holding the imaginary glass)

You got a half a glass a water . . . "And . . . uh . . . you should drink the water," that's what he said. . .

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(Sheepish – he didn't get the saying right – he turns away, then laughs at himself.)

No, that isn't what he said . . . He said . . . he said . . . "Half a glass of water is better than no water at all!" That's it. "Half a glass of water is better than no water . . . " (Full of energy again)

I look at it this way – I could be living in Ethiopia. Those poor people got it terrible. They got nothing to eat. Starving all the time. They just sit in the sand all day long . . . It's too sunny, too many flies . . . it's not for me. It's not my bag. I prefer it here . . . it's better here. (Lost in thought, convincing himself)

It's good here, it's good. It's good. Thank God! (Pause. He's just standing, staring at the ground. He snaps out of it – sunny, cheerful again, he addresses the audience.)

Well, I gotta get going, got to get to work. You know what they say: "The early bird catches the can!"

Or bottles . . . bottles or cans, it don't make no difference . . . It don't make no difference at all . . . .

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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